

“All the News
That’s Fit to Print”

The New York Times

THE WEATHER
Today, early fog, mostly sunny, high 49. **Tonight**, increasing clouds, low 34. **Tomorrow**, colder, early snow, mostly sunny in the afternoon, high 38. Weather map is on Page A24.

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Prices in Canada may be higher

\$4.00



A blackout in Havana last week. President Trump has pummeled Cuba’s economy by forcing cutoffs of fuel shipments to the island. YAMIL LAGE/AGENCE FRANCE-PRESSE — GETTY IMAGES

SAVVY STRATEGIES SET WARNER SALE

Playing Off Paramount
Against Netflix

By **BENJAMIN MULLIN**
and **LAUREN HIRSCH**

Three years ago, David Zaslav, the chief executive of Warner Bros. Discovery, had major headaches. The company’s movie studio was in third place, despite a blockbuster performance for “Barbie.” He was slashing costs and shelving projects, turning his once-warm relationship with Hollywood frosty. Shares hit \$13, down from nearly \$25 when he took control.

One article, in GQ, described Mr. Zaslav as “the most hated man in Hollywood” and compared him to the ruthless tycoon played by Richard Gere in “Pretty Woman.” Mr. Zaslav is getting the last laugh now.

On Thursday, Netflix dropped out of the bidding for Warner Bros., clearing the way for Paramount to acquire the company for \$31 per share, or \$111 billion. It was more than double the company’s valuation in September, before news of Paramount’s interest became public.

The deal is a huge win for shareholders and for Mr. Zaslav, the conclusion of a bidding war he played a major role in engineering.

If the deal closes, it will put two major movie studios, Warner Bros. and Paramount Pictures, under the same roof, and combine two news powerhouses in CBS News and CNN.

The deal will also make Mr. Zaslav — one of the most highly compensated chief executives in corporate America for years — an even richer man. The sale to Paramount values Mr. Zaslav’s shares and his other outstanding equity in Warner Bros. Discovery at roughly \$790.5 million, according to an analysis from Equilar.

“This whole process has been challenging, it’s been exciting, it’s been thrilling,” Mr. Zaslav said, speaking on the phone from New York, where he had completed a marathon of board meetings. “And I’m glad that it landed with

Continued on Page A19

CNN A change in ownership means an uncertain future for the news organization. **PAGE B1**

Trump Open to a Deal With Cuba to Avert Chaos

By **MICHAEL CROWLEY**

WASHINGTON — With a U.S. chokehold pushing Cuba’s economy toward potential collapse, President Trump is hoping to reach a deal with the island’s communist government to avoid chaos even if it means the leadership change long sought by many of his close allies has to wait.

Instead, Mr. Trump appears to be pursuing a version of his approach to Venezuela, whose leftist government remained in power after U.S. troops captured its president, Nicolás Maduro, in January.

On Wednesday, Cuban border guards shot and killed four Cuban nationals who departed from the United States as they approached

*One Option Is a Change
in Leaders, but Not
Government*

the island’s coast in a boat. It is unclear whether the episode will affect the Trump administration’s plans.

After years of calling for Venezuela’s opposition leaders to take power, Mr. Trump has cooperated with Mr. Maduro’s successor to gain American access to the country’s oil, leaving questions about a political transition for later.

Similarly, Mr. Trump does not want a sudden power vacuum in

Havana, according to a senior administration official and an associate of Secretary of State Marco Rubio, as well as Mr. Rubio’s own public remarks in recent weeks. Mr. Rubio has spoken about a potential deal with Raúl Guillermo Rodríguez Castro, the grandson of Fidel Castro’s brother, Raúl, according to two people familiar with the matter.

Mr. Rubio, who steers Mr. Trump’s Latin America policy, is a son of Cuban immigrants who has long called for the government’s downfall. But after a meeting with Caribbean leaders on Wednesday, Mr. Rubio sounded willing to wait.

“Cuba needs to change,” Mr. Rubio said. But, he added, “it doesn’t have to change all at once. It does-

Continued on Page A8

Victims’ Families Stunned At Failure of Air Safety Bill

House Alternative After D.C. Midair Crash
Faces Icy Reception in the Senate

By **KAROUN DEMIRJIAN**

WASHINGTON — The victims’ families were worried. For months, they had waited for the House to pick up a bill to enact new rules on aircraft that officials have said might have prevented a midair collision over Washington last year that killed 67 people. But the chairman of the House committee overseeing aviation had made it clear he was not a fan of the legislation, called the ROTOR Act.

“Are you going to work to kill ROTOR?” Tim Lilley, the father of one of the airplane pilots, asked a senior panel aide during a virtual meeting between congressional staff members and the victims’ families, according to four people who recalled the conversation.

No, the staff member said. Representative Sam Graves, Republican of Missouri and the chairman of the Transportation and Infrastructure Committee, would promote his own alternate legislation, but not work to kill the RO-

TOR Act. The families left feeling confident that the bill would pass.

Less than a week later, the families watched in shock from the House gallery as Republican leaders tanked the legislation in open forum.

The photo-finish downfall of the ROTOR Act, which narrowly failed, stunned the families, who had taken days off work and traveled from as far as Colorado to watch what they believed would be the culmination of their 13-month lobbying effort for new aviation safety laws. Instead, their impassioned campaign ran head-first into the meat grinder of congressional politics, which let them down at multiple junctures — and left the prospects of aviation safety legislation unclear.

“The whole thing felt like an exercise in bad faith,” said Rachel Feres, whose cousin, Peter Livingston; his wife, Donna; and their two daughters, Everly and

Continued on Page A13

Defiant Maduro Failed to See That Time Was Running Out

This article is by Anatoly Kurmanov, Mariana Martínez and Tyler Pager.

CARACAS, Venezuela — An armada of U.S. warships and fighter jets sat menacingly off Venezuela’s waters, and the Pentagon had already devised plans to capture or kill the country’s leader.

But as 2025 ended, President Nicolás Maduro seemed surprisingly relaxed, celebrating New Year’s Eve with a small group of family and friends at home in Caracas, the capital, according to several people close to him, including one guest at the party.

They shared traditional Vene-

Hubris and Missteps in
Final Days of Power

zuelan dishes like hallacas and pan de jamón. They listened to gaitas, fast-paced Venezuelan Christmas songs.

The next day, as usual, Mr. Maduro sent greetings to his senior officials. “Happy New Year to you and your family,” read one message viewed by The New York Times.

The United States threatened to attack Venezuela if Mr. Maduro

Continued on Page A6



AJG Growth Fund LLC, registered in Delaware, owns units in the Austin Proper Hotel, left; Earhardt Manor LLC in Texas bought a house, center, that is used by Elon Musk’s Ad Astra School LLC; and Gapped Bass LLC holds land for the Boring Company, right. JORDAN VONDERHAAR FOR THE NEW YORK TIMES



Ad Astra School LLC, identified as Musk School, is used by Elon Musk. MERIDITH KOHUT FOR THE NEW YORK TIMES



Gapped Bass LLC holds land for the Boring Company, right. MERIDITH KOHUT FOR THE NEW YORK TIMES

Secret Web of Companies Is Helping Musk Cloak His Spending

This article is by Kirsten Grind, Susanne Craig and Alex Klavens.

AUSTIN, Texas — In 2020, Elon Musk announced he was moving to Texas from California and embarking on a personal austerity campaign to strip his life of belongings.

“I am selling almost all physical possessions,” he posted on social media. “Will own no house.”

But in the years since, Mr. Musk, 54, has quietly built an em-

pire of more than 90 companies and other legal entities in Texas, which have amassed a vast collection of assets, according to an examination by The New York Times.

The secretive network offers a glimpse into just how central one of the world’s richest men, who has a net worth of more than \$650 billion, has made Texas to his operations and ambitions. More than 50 of his at least 90 companies there are subsidiaries or other entities affiliated with his

A Way to Funnel Funds
to Trump’s Campaign

business empire, such as the rocket company SpaceX and the electric vehicle maker Tesla, as well as his nonprofit Musk Foundation.

But The Times identified at least 37 companies that appeared to be largely for Mr. Musk’s per-

sonal use. Among them was one that owns two multimillion-dollar condominiums totaling more than 7,000 square feet in the Austin Proper Hotel, with sweeping views of downtown. Other companies managed planes that Mr. Musk uses for private travel and a portfolio of more than 1,000 acres of land, which when combined is bigger than Central Park in New York. The lines between Mr. Musk’s business and personal in-

Continued on Page A18

Birthrate Falls As More Wait To Be Parents

By **SABRINA TAVERNISE**
and **JEFF ADELSON**

The U.S. birthrate is declining. Rose Paz’s choices help explain why.

Ms. Paz, 22, grew up in Salt Lake City, the eldest of three children, born when her mother, an immigrant from Mexico, was 16. Her parents, a waitress and a cook, worked a lot, leaving her responsible for her younger siblings. She remembers having to skip sleepovers and birthday parties to care for them.

Ms. Paz is studying for a bachelor’s degree in marketing. She has a serious boyfriend, but she does not want to have children now.

“I want to be financially stable and in a place I can call my own,” she said. “I saw my parents get stressed over money, and I don’t want my kid to experience that.”

Not so long ago, women like Ms. Paz — in their early 20s, from backgrounds that are far from privileged — would have been among the most likely to be having children.

Now this group is a key contributor to the country’s declining birthrate, which is at an all-time low, down by over 25 percent since 2007, the year the fall began.

The decline has prompted hand-wringing among portions of the political class, with some conservatives calling it the triumph of

Continued on Page A12



INTERNATIONAL A4-10

Pakistan-Afghanistan Clash

Pakistani airstrikes came after Afghan troops attacked Pakistani border positions, prompting “open war.” **PAGE A5**

Iranians Cite Progress in Talks

Representatives of Tehran and the U.S. discussed the fate of Iran’s nuclear program, but made no deal. **PAGE A9**

NATIONAL A11-19

Prison Divides Arkansas G.O.P.

Gov. Sarah Huckabee Sanders hopes to oust fellow Republicans in Tuesday’s primary to build a pricey 3,000-bed facility that they oppose. **PAGE A11**

Clinton Testifies on Epstein

After the ex-president answered questions from a House panel, Democrats signaled that they could now force President Trump to appear. **PAGE A16**

Trump Halts Use of Anthropic

The order comes after a standoff between the company and the Pentagon over how military officials wanted to use its cutting-edge A.I. model. **PAGE A16**

BUSINESS B1-5

India’s Economy Is on the Rise

Poised to assume the world’s fourth spot, the nation’s economy has grown rapidly despite slow industrialization, and is nearly as big as Japan’s. **PAGE B1**

A Story of Tech’s Effects

In a landmark trial, a plaintiff said that YouTube and Instagram caused her harm as early as age 6. **PAGE B1**

SPORTS B6-9

Open Arms and Barbecue

The Kansas City area has become a desired World Cup base for some of the world’s soccer powers. **PAGE B6**

TRAVEL C7-8

Tintin’s Trans-Atlantic Voyage

How would a 10-year-old terrier mutt, averse to flying, fare during eight days at sea on the Queen Mary 2? **PAGE C7**



ARTS C1-6

Gore Becomes ‘The Pitt’

Protruding bones, visible organs and buckets of blood can put the medical drama’s team to the test. **PAGE C1**

A Dance Company Delight

A stellar double bill features Rauschenberg-designed works by Merce Cunningham and Trisha Brown. **PAGE C1**

OPINION A22-23

Linda Greenhouse **PAGE A22**

